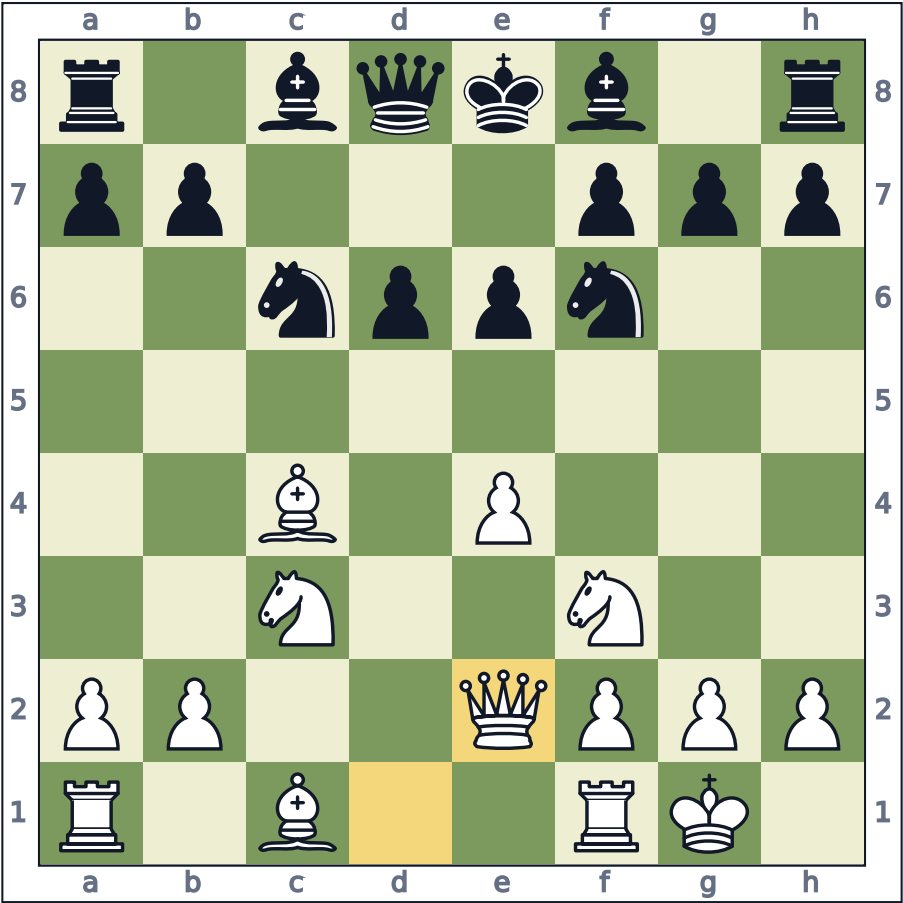


Smith-Morra Gambit

A ground-up visual course for practical play



Core route position - gold marks the last move

WHITE FOCUS

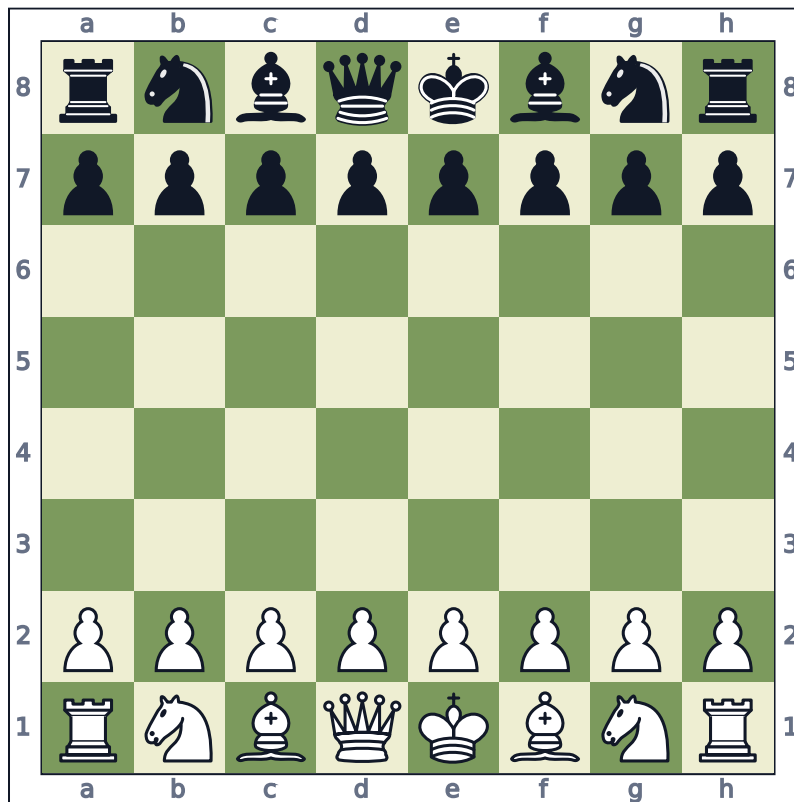
OPENING IDENTITY

White gives a pawn for open lines, fast development, and immediate initiative.

ORIENTATION

Ground zero: read the board and the moves

White starts from ranks 1-2; Black starts from ranks 7-8. Files run a through h. Each lesson highlights the last move in gold so your eyes connect notation to the board.



Starting position - White to move

HOW ALGEBRAIC NOTATION WORKS

Nf3 means a knight moves to f3. B means bishop, R rook, Q queen, K king; pawns use only the destination square. An x means capture, + means check, and O-O means kingside castling.

YOUR FIRST ANCHOR

Say the first moves aloud, then point to every destination square:

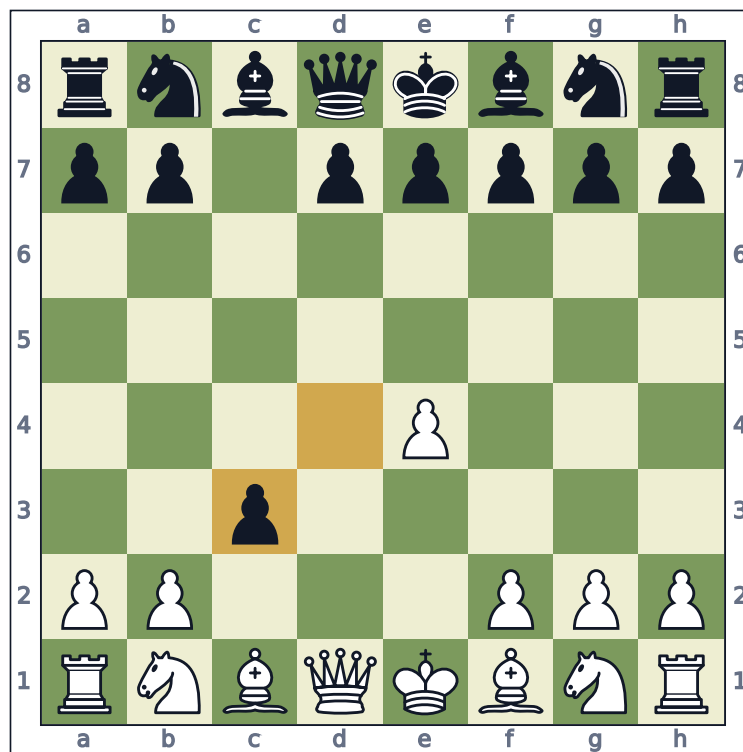
1. e4 c5 2. d4 cxd4 3. c3 dxc3

Course promise: Development and open files are the compensation.

MOVES 1-3

Lesson 1: the first conversation

1. e4 c5 2. d4 cxd4 3. c3 dxc3



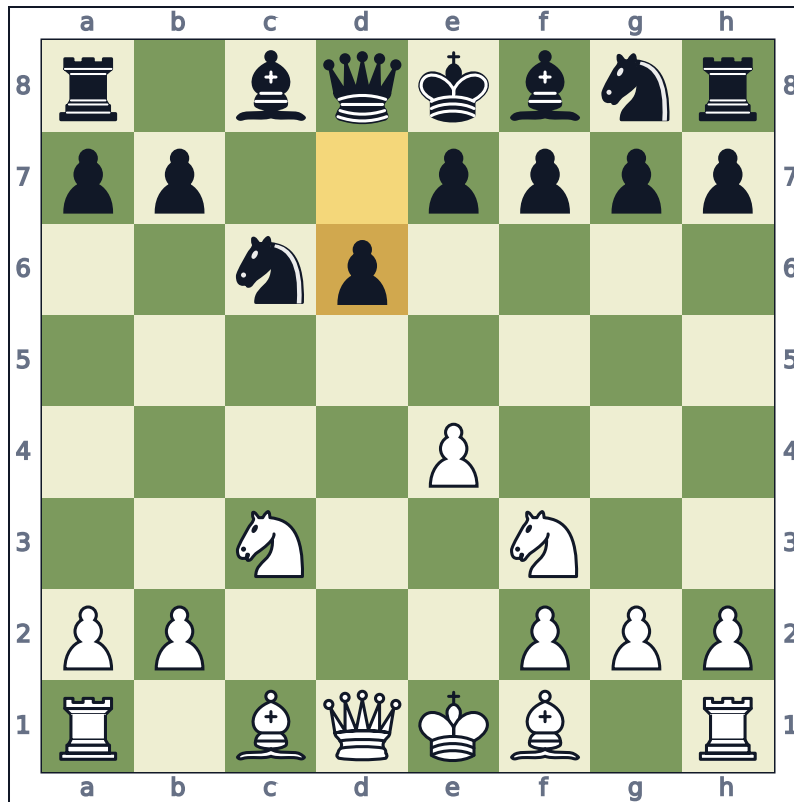
After 3. c3 dxc3

- 1. e4 - Claims or challenges central space and opens a line for a piece.
- 1... c5 - Creates a lever against the center or supports a coming break.
- 2. d4 - Claims or challenges central space and opens a line for a piece.
- 2... cxd4 - Resolves central tension and changes the pawn structure.
- 3. c3 - Creates a lever against the center or supports a coming break.
- 3... dxc3 - Resolves central tension and changes the pawn structure.

DEVELOPMENT

Lesson 2: build the core position

1. e4 c5 2. d4 cxd4 3. c3 dxc3 4. Nxc3 Nc6 5. Nf3 d6



White to move

WHAT THE PIECES ARE BUILDING

White gives a pawn for open lines, fast development, and immediate initiative.

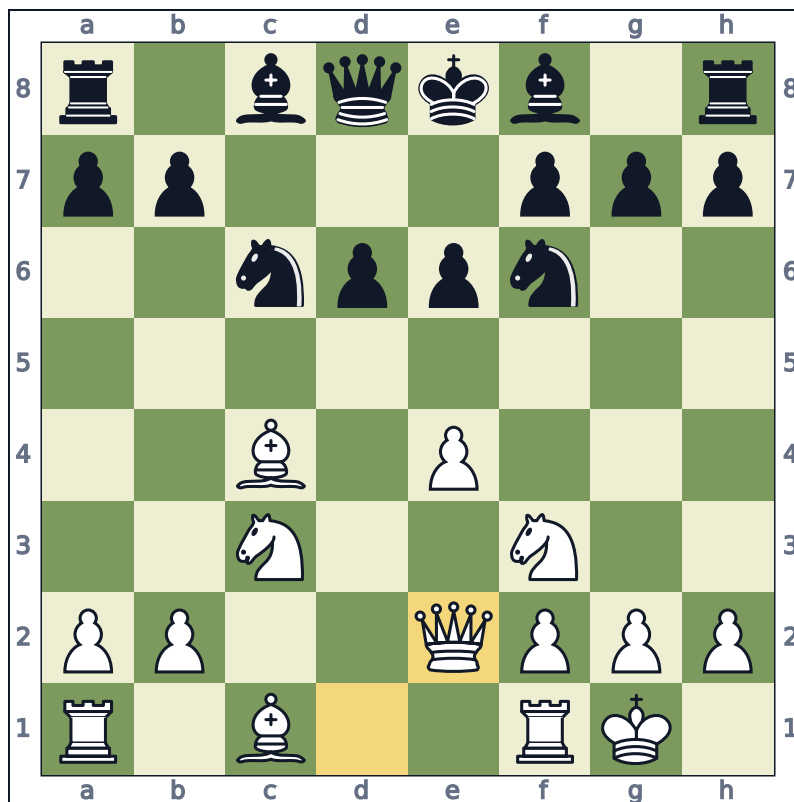
BEGINNER CHECKPOINT

Before copying the next move, ask: Is my king safe? Which piece is still at home? What changed in the center? Which pawn break is each side preparing?

CORE LINE

Lesson 3: complete the main route

1. e4 c5 2. d4 cxd4 3. c3 dxc3 4. Nxc3 Nc6 5. Nf3 d6 6. Bc4 Nf6 7. O-O e6 8. Qe2



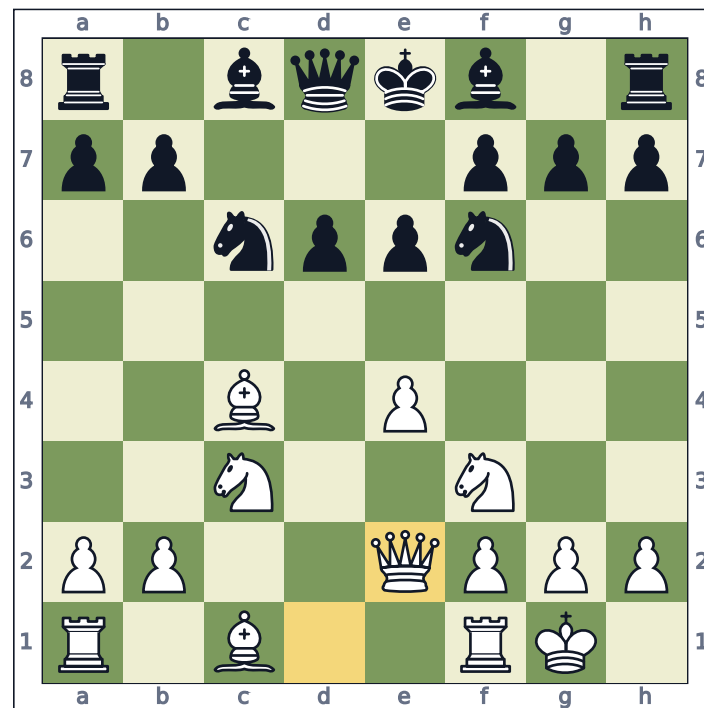
Core position - now plans matter more than memorized moves

DO NOT MEMORIZE BLINDLY

The route is a model, not a forced script. Its job is to teach this relationship: White gives a pawn for open lines, fast development, and immediate initiative. If the opponent deviates, preserve the same priorities until a concrete tactic changes them.

UNDERSTANDING

The position map: plans for both sides



Read plans from the pawn structure, not from the opening name

WHITE'S PLAN

Put rooks on open files, develop every piece, and attack before queens are traded.

BLACK'S PLAN

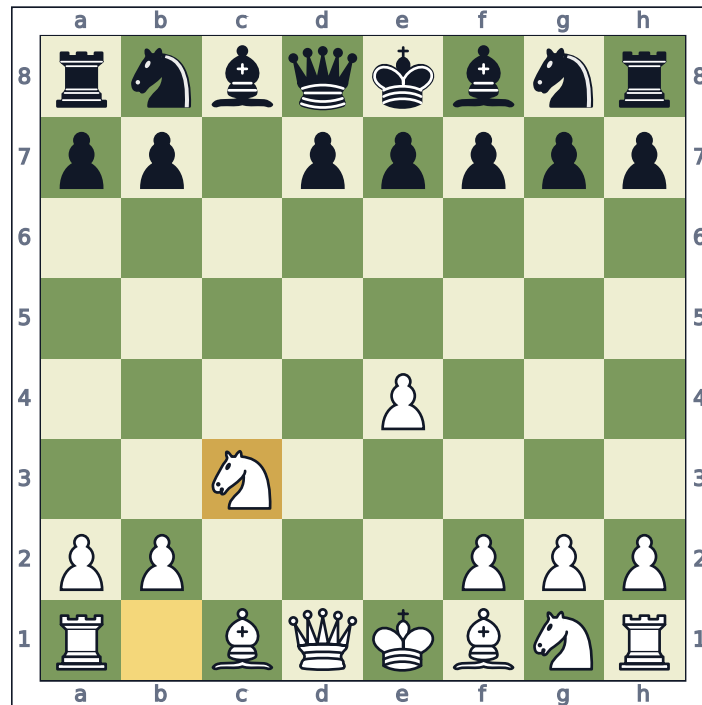
Complete development, return material if necessary, and blunt White's activity with accurate defense.

THE LEVER TO REMEMBER

White may use e5; Black often seeks ...d5 to neutralize the initiative.

CALCULATION

Tactical literacy: what can suddenly change



Pause here - Black to move

THEME

Rook pressure on d1 and sacrifices on e6 or f7 can punish one slow defensive move.

COMMON BEGINNER ERROR

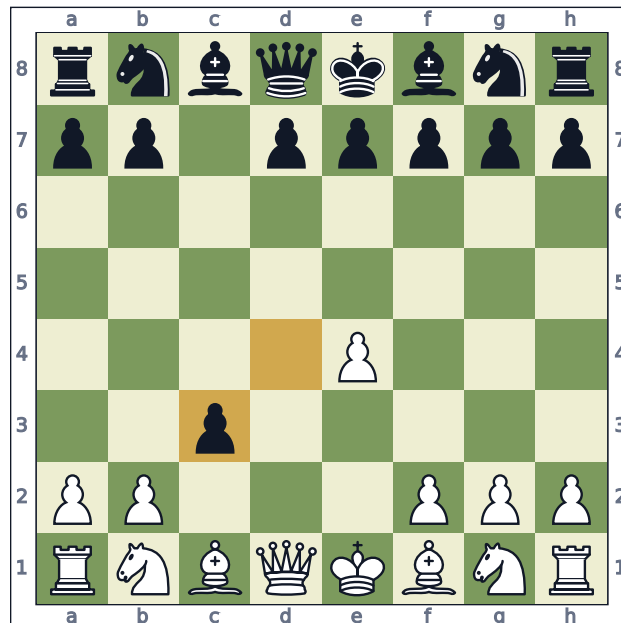
Trying to recover the pawn instead of using the open files it purchased.

THREE-SECOND SAFETY SCAN

1. Checks against both kings. 2. Captures in the center. 3. Threats against loose or pinned pieces.

ADAPTATION

Decision tree: when the opponent leaves the route



A branch point - principles are your map

1. If the center stays fluid

Finish development and keep the opening identity in view: White gives a pawn for open lines, fast development, and immediate initiative.

2. If the center closes

Use the pawn-chain direction. Attack the base before making wing moves that cannot be supported.

3. If the center opens

Prioritize king safety, active pieces, and checks or captures before slow pawn moves.

4. If nothing is forced

Return to the planned lever: White may use e5; Black often seeks ...d5 to neutralize the initiative.

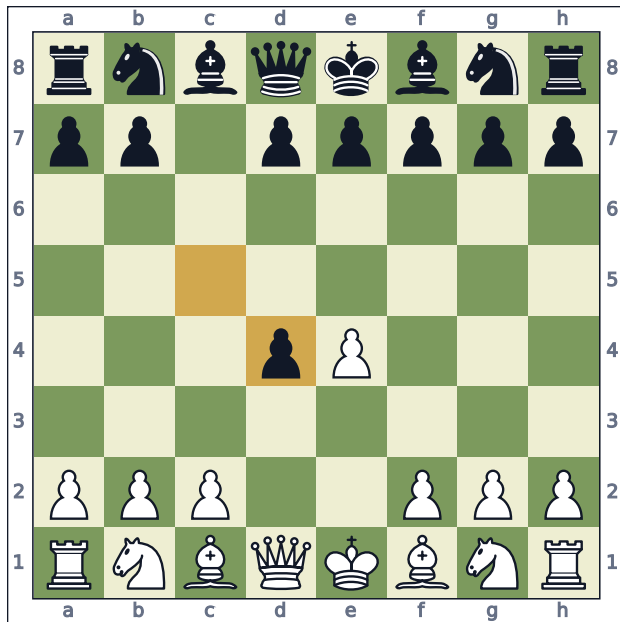
MEMORY SENTENCE

Development and open files are the compensation.

ACTIVE RECALL

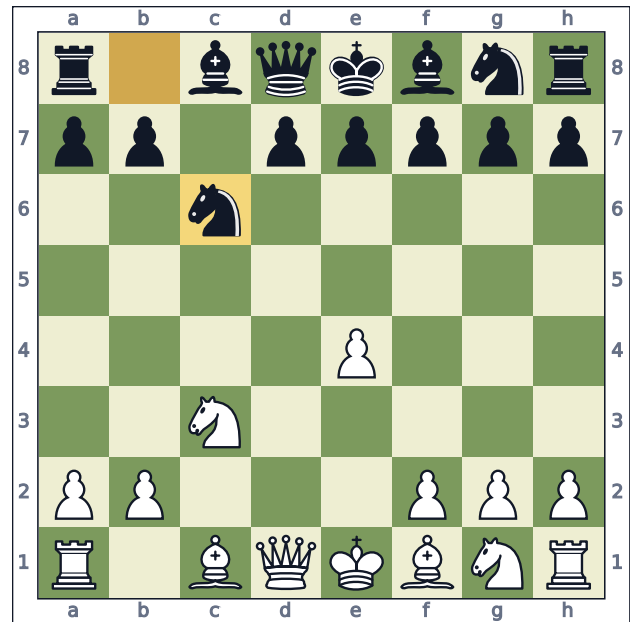
Recall test: answer before you turn the page

POSITION A



White to move

POSITION B



White to move

- A1. What is the next route move for White?
- A2. What opening problem does that move solve?
- B1. What is the next route move for White?
- B2. Name one plan for White and one plan for Black.
- C. State the thematic pawn break without looking back.

SCORING

5/5: replay from memory. 3-4/5: review Lessons 3 and 6. 0-2/5: return to Lesson 1 and rebuild the route slowly.

RETENTION

Answer key and a 14-day practice loop

POSITION A

Next route move: c3. Explain it using development, center, king safety, or a direct tactical need.

POSITION B

Next route move: Nf3. Then compare the position with the final core board.

PLAN AND BREAK ANSWERS

White: Put rooks on open files, develop every piece, and attack before queens are traded. Black: Complete development, return material if necessary, and blunt White's activity with accurate defense. Lever: White may use e5; Black often seeks ...d5 to neutralize the initiative.

14-DAY LOOP

- Days 1-2: replay the first three moves from both sides and name each move's job.
- Days 3-4: build the core position from memory; correct the first error, then restart.
- Days 5-6: say White's plan, Black's plan, and the pawn break without a board.
- Day 7: take the recall test. Record the score; do not count lucky guesses.
- Days 8-10: play three slow practice games, starting from the core position if possible.
- Days 11-13: review only mistakes and deviations that actually occurred in your games.
- Day 14: retake the test and write a one-sentence opening rule in your own words.